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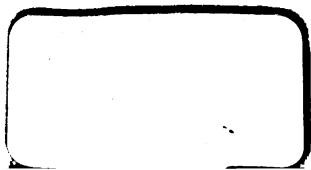
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The Quest of the Holy Grail.

Charles F. Bradley.



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THE QUEST OF THE HOLY GRAIL

BY

CHARLES F. BRADLEY



BOSTON

JAMES H. WEST, PUBLISHER

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"Sweet brother, I have seen the Holy Grail:
For, waked at dead of night, I heard a sound
As of a silver horn from o'er the hills.
 And the slender sound
As from a distance beyond distance grew
Coming upon me. Oh, never harp nor horn,
Nor aught we blow with breath or touch with hand,
Was like that music as it came. And then
Stream'd through my cell a cold and silver beam,
And down the long beam stole the Holy Grail,
Rose-red with beatings in it, as if alive,
Till all the white walls of my cell were dyed
With rosy colors leaping on the wall;
And then the music faded, and the Grail
Past, and the beam decay'd, and from the walls
The rosy quiverings died into the night.
So, now the Holy Thing is here again
Among us, brother, fast thou too and pray,
And tell thy brother knights to fast and pray,
That so perhaps the Vision may be seen
By thee and those, and all the world be heal'd."

—*Idyls of the King.*





The Quest of the Holy Grail.



IN the ancient Druidical religion it was the custom of the savage priestesses who assisted at the sacrifice to collect the blood of the victim in a bowl. By virtue of this office the bowl was supposed to become an incarnation of the divinity who had previously incarnated himself in the sacrifice. It was held in highest sanctity. It possessed miraculous powers. It was the heart of the mysteries, the potent charm in all the magic and jugglery of the savage religion.

Those old Druids were a people of no mean intelligence of an imaginative order, and they were doubtless the authors of legends, woven about their mystic symbol,

which in later ages, when Druidism had disappeared before Christianity, became the Arthurian legends with which Tennyson has made the literary world familiar. The Holy Grail of mediæval chivalry was this old pagan sacrificial bowl garnished with a cycle of Christian myths. Christianity in this, as in so many other instances, appropriated the virile ideals of the Druidical cult, and elaborated them into fitting imagery and symbol for its own richer intellectual life. The transformation was artistically done. I greatly admire the romantic genius of those Middle Ages. No poets of modern time have surpassed it in nobility. Wagner and Tennyson have beautifully adorned the old legends, but they have not excelled the poetic skill of the original creators of Parsifal and Lohengrin, Lancelot and Galahad.

It was reputed that Joseph of Arimathea, having obtained from Pilate the basin from which Jesus had eaten the Paschal Supper,

and having collected in it some drops of his blood as he hung on the cross, brought it to Britain and committed it to the keeping of the Knights of the Round Table, a circle of consecrated heroes of unblemished character and distinguished prowess. They were under solemn vows to keep themselves "unspotted from the world," to defend their sacred charge from sacrilege, and, inspired by its mystic power, to "fight the good fight of faith" with their invincible swords and conquer the heathen world to the standard of the Cross. The old story of human frailty in their case, as in every case of human endeavor, interfered with the carrying out of the divine scheme. The heroes of the Round Table easily conquered the "enemies of the Cross," but they found it not so easy a matter to conquer themselves and fulfil their vows. One of the number was overcome by the "temptations of the flesh," and the charmed circle was broken, the Holy

Grail vanished from the sight of men, its mystic power was lost, and the grand Campaign of the Cross languished in dark vicissitudes. But then came the next chapter in the old story, the awakening of a mighty hunger to recover the lost gift, around which Romance twined luxuriantly its legends of the noble knights consecrating themselves in solemn fealty to the great Cause, searching the whole earth over and bearing all hardship and danger to obtain once more a vision of the vanished Grail and again be made invincible by its mystic power.

I can understand the charm which the old legends had as the old bards sung them; which they still have as sung in the passionate strains of Wagner and Tennyson. To know whence the legends sprung, to appreciate their deathless sweetness, one needs only to get the fact throbbing forcefully in his veins that, six hundred years ago, men *lived*. They had hearts. They had hopes.

They had dreams which the world was not large enough to fill. They had strivings which were baffled by infirmities. They had the crushing load of disappointment and pain. They *lived* all the witchery of life's illusion, all the tragedy of its bitterness and terror. Frailty bore them down in defeat, tore their dreams into shreds, wrapped their destinies in cold, impenetrable mystery. It was out of their cry for light and for help that the old legends rose, singing courage and hope, and the sweet by-and-by of life's power and triumph.

This Grail of the old romance,—is it not a symbol of the Beautiful Soul that lies hidden somewhere among God's beautiful things, full of grace and gladness? the symbol of the passionate yearning of the heart for a life riding on the light high above the earth-enveloping mystery, filled and enriched by the deathless power of love and peace and joyous endeavor?

Do we not know this Holy Grail? We know the mystery! Through all the thousand ages of man's struggle it has never been lifted. It lies upon our paths heavy and impenetrable as ever. We have our dreams, and the rough awakening from them. We follow infatuation, and it breaks us on the terrible rocks. Frailties beset us, and rout our strivings, and hedge us in uncongenial environments, and send us plodding through the monotony of distasteful drudgery. We have cares and anxieties that take all joy of fruition out of our brightest ambitions. Aches and ills poison the daily sunshine, disappointments and sorrows rob the months of sweetness. We live, and the years grow shorter and fewer as we live, and the wonder of it all is veiled by the ashen poverty of it all; the romance dies out of our vision; we eat the daily commonplace unseasoned by the salt of rest; our sodden minds bend to the deepening contest with Nature, in order that we may hold our footing and escape the abyss. And what with passion crying unanswered

cries, and mistakes undoing bravery and hope,
and our star-born life driven to dickering
with Destiny to stretch its span a brief hand-
breadth, we find ourselves echoing the lines
of Lowell,

“Earth gets its price for what earth gives us ;
The beggar is taxed for a corner to die in,
The priest hath his fee who comes and shrives us,
We bargain for the graves we lie in.
At the devil's booth are all things sold ;
Each ounce of dross costs its ounce of gold ;
For a cap and bells our lives we pay.”

We know all about this sodden mystery
of failure ! But is this the whole of it ? Do
we not also know *the Grail*, the passion of the
Beautiful Soul and its destiny,—

“ . . . the island-valley of Avilion,
Where falls not hail, or rain, or any snow,
Nor ever wind blows loudly ; but it lies
Deep-meadow'd, happy, fair with orchard lawns
And bowery hollows crown'd with summer sea,”

where life shall heal itself of all its wounds ?

Amid the toil and drudgery and weariness and ache are intimations, omens, in our natures, of which we make little note, but which have a wonderful interpretation. *The lost Grail* is hidden in our hearts! There are signs which show us where it lies; where to make search for it.

Our careers are like the woods and fields in Winter. Over the hillsides and the meadows stretch the white, still, snow-clad wastes, with never a song of bird or glinting of sunbeams from shining buttercups. Yet underneath the old dead leaves, in the sheltered nook, I shall find a hardy vine still nestling, and fresh red berries, and even tender buds. In this remnant of last Summer's life I have a promise of all the sumptuousness of another June. I know that under the snows are hiding ten thousand forms of beauty which will come forth to greet the May-day.

Human lives are snow-bound: I know it! Storms of freezing Winter sweep them. Icy

environments lock fast their springs. The May-day song is not heard in the winds of disappointment and discontent. No blossoms peep out of the cold, silent round of monotonous toil in which hearts plod and die. Ignorance and blundering and adversity, it may be, stretch like gray clouds from horizon to horizon, and shut off all high vision and hope. Yet there are buds under the dry, dead leaves. Lives there one so wrapped up in himself, in the rebuffs, vexations, disappointments, discontents of destiny, that there is not something which takes him out of himself, something to which he gives sweet interest and solicitude, something which he loves? That something may be only his dog, his rifle, a flower-pot in the window. But no matter what it is,—what a rent it makes in the veil of mystery! And what unfathomable grandeur of soul-destiny glimmers through the rent! With sedulous care he guards his trusty rifle, with tender touch he brushes the dust from the dawning rose-bud, his last crust he

shares with his faithful dog. And lo! the distant skies light up with a beam of the Holy Grail that shoots from the deep mystery of his heart. He may be a human devil,—a Bill Sykes, if you remember the character in “*Oliver Twist*”; a ruffian every inch of him, with a nature black as Tophet, as devoid of the instinct of tenderness as a famished tiger, scrupling not to cleave with an axe the skull of the only woman who had ever trusted and loved him. Yet, as we see him bestowing his coarse, rude caresses upon his dog, a cur as ugly and vicious as himself, a ray of light bursting out of infinite depths steals over the grim character and softens for the instant its hard features.

These buds of the Beautiful Soul,—how many of them there are slumbering under the snows! Through the stormiest Winter of experience a man will carry hidden away in his heart a violet that has upon it the dew of Springtime. In yonder shop is a hard-faced workman. He associates with nobody. His fellows know of

him only as he stands there at the bench, indifferent to everything but his work, and little interested in that. His manner repels friendly advances, and they leave him alone. He has a history the blotted scrawl of which they are not permitted to read. He is proud and jealous. In youth he was ambitious, and strove desperately for success; but he lacked the ability for the success he sought. He could not compete with his more skilful rivals: they outstripped him, and, worst of all, wrested his little fortune from his tight grasp, and he was left penniless. His disappointment has embittered him. He rebels at his lot, is morose and silent, and at enmity with the world. Yet there is a moment in that man's daily life when the hard features relax, when the cold, dull light of the eye brightens and sparkles, and the jealousies and antipathies and mortifications are forgotten. There is a Morning Star looking softly down upon the dark, silent field of his destiny. It is when his little daughter, a bright-eyed four-year-old, comes

trotting down to the gate at evening-time to meet him. He lifts his idol to his cheek, and chubby hands tangle themselves in the grimy beard, and baby lips press softly against his own. Under his frozen exterior hides this bud, fresh and fragrant; the cold, sour life has at least this much of divinity that the Winter does not kill. This spot in the man's life keeps ever sweet and warm.

How little we think what a Holy Grail this parent-love is in man or woman. All of the exalting hopes of girlhood may have been blighted from a woman's life; she may have had to bear a sadness that darkens all her pathway and gives her no hope of rest this side the grave. Yet the glow of mother-love, like calm twilight, streams down the years and kindles the edges of the clouds that overhang her. Neglect, cruelty, faithlessness, may have crushed her spirits and shot poisoned arrows into her heart; yet that heart will forget the sting of the arrows, and throb with the sweet anguish of devotion for a

wayward child whom the world calls worthless and thrusts aside.

Underneath, we all have this other life, which the world sees not,—these hidden blossoms of a quenchless Springtime. We never get so hardened by our disappointments and our jealousies that affection wholly freezes. There will be someone whose presence will soften the gloom on our brows, whose finger-touch will thrill with a flash of light our deepest despair, who holds the key to our natures and can open up in us a wealth of nobleness which is locked away from other eyes. All the while that our destinies seem the barren and unattractive destinies which we know, we are hiding from the cynical world, each one of us, his own violet which never fades, and which fills the inner sanctuary of our better selves with the sweetness of divinity.

Do we rightly realize the greatness which this implies? This Holy Grail which coyly, fitfully flashes upon us, flower-like, in these sweetnesses of human nature,—do we even in small part

appreciate the depths of knightly power in man which shelter and fructify it when the miracle in it shines to clothe the Beautiful Soul with divinity? We are greater than we know! Our eyes,—whether filled with dust or with tears,—are they not always strained upward? Is the farthest and bluest height above us ever utterly beyond the anguish of our yearning, in our struggle for the beatific life? We are depressed with the futilities that mockingly come in answer to the cry of our passion; yet still our passion cries. We fling off the futilities, and still look upward if the gods will rend the darkness and show our aching feet the path of sweet destiny.

Amiel, the saint of Geneva, in his *Journal* writes, speaking of himself: "In the name of Heaven, who art thou,—what wilt thou,—waver-
ing, inconstant creature? What future lies before thee? What duty or what hope appeals to thee? My longing, my search, is for love, for peace, for something to fill my heart; an idea

to defend; a work to which I might devote the remainder of my strength; an affection which might quench this inner thirst; a cause for which I might die with joy. But shall I ever find these? I long for all that is impossible and inaccessible; for true religion, serious sympathy, the ideal life; for paradise, immortality, holiness, faith, inspiration, and I know not what beside!"

It is the Quest of the Grail, this passion of Amiel! His cry is the immortal cry of life. It is the soul of all grand human endeavor, of all heroism, of all art, poetry and song. The measures of opera and oratorio that sweep us with ineffable passion are the footsteps of Galahad on the Quest of the Grail. The chisel of the sculptor cuts the path to the Grail. The brushes of Raphael and Millet spread the light of the Grail over the dream of human hope. All deathless poetry and romance, all creations of the infinite human ideal, are born of the vision of the Grail. The Galahads attain the vision.

Whittier and Lowell and Holmes attain the vision. Longfellow and Tennyson and Browning attain the vision. Goethe and George Eliot and Emerson attain the vision. The inspired books that we love, the bibles of our heart-struggle,—do we know the secret of their power? They have souls! They are immortally human with life's heroic quest and dream of hope. They are to us our own human heart attained to the heights of God and the enduring royalty of existence. It is the long Quest of the Grail and its glory which makes them live anew, and live on, in us. Deep within them, unobserved by the thoughtless eye, we come upon the Galahads on the search, standing on the mountain-tops, their brows touched with the vision of life. Do the Galahads and the Launfals ever die? Will Amiel ever die? Will George Eliot ever die while the world stands? If we step reverently into the sanctuary where they sit crowned with the vision, we come not forth

from the audience without the warm breath from their living lips on our brows.

The key to the beatific life,—is it not here coming in sight? are not our fingers touching it? The futilities, the failure and heart-ache, of which we know so much,—how largely they are the direct consequence of selfishness in us, or of our being the victims of selfishness in others! The ignorance, the blunders, which fix us in our hard, irritating environment,—it was, in part, somebody's selfishness that laid the train of heredity which sprung them upon us. In part, I say: for we do not realize how fatally we are compelled to self-brooding, to poverty of experience, to the sadness of always looking downward with bitter thoughts of the "cruelties of destiny" which rend our dreams and shut out the vision of beauty, for a reason other than that of inheritance,—namely, because we have not, as Amiel puts it, "Something to fill the heart; an idea to defend, a work to which to

devote strength, an affection to quench the inner thirst, a cause for which to die with joy”!

The buds within us are awaiting the May-day of a deathless Ideal whose passion bursts through our lives like the quenchless power of summer skies. We are desultory and ephemeral and at odds with shifting caprice, we drift on the tide of impotent circumstance, until with clear-eyed purpose, unincumbered by selfish motive, our feet start on the Quest of the Grail. And as the June of love and peace deepens in the sky the Ideal in the heart blooms and scatters sweetness, and the summer vision breaks on the Beautiful Soul.

When our footsteps burn with the divine quest we forget that life is hard, forget that we fail.

“Joy comes, grief goes, we know not how;
Everything is happy now,
Everything is upward striving;

'Tis as easy now for the heart to be true
As for grass to be green or skies to be blue,—
'Tis the natural way of living:
Who knows whither the clouds have fled?
In the unscarred heaven they leave no wake;
And the eyes forget the tears they have shed,
The heart forgets its sorrow and ache."

Environments melt, as Winter melts in April, if the heat of a glowing purpose of human good burns in our sky. Our faith in the future will be bright and grand by what grandeur of daily achievement we are able to take along in our hands to greet it. Sir Launfal gives himself to the leper, and the miracle-working Grail puts the deathless power of God into his soul. Darwin gives himself to science, and the Grail puts the world into his hand to take down the long journey of time. Intoxicated with the heroism of uplifting humanity by inspired achievement, we see no earth with its ephemeral futilities,—we see only the Beautiful Soul on the heights, flooded with vision.

To him whose feet are on this august quest,

“Let visions of the night or of the day
Come, as they will ! And many a time they come,
Until this earth he walks on seems not earth,
This light that strikes his eyeball is not light,
This air that smites his forehead is not air,
But vision — yea, his very hand and foot —
In moments when he feels he cannot die.”

Raphael's painting, in the Louvre, of Saint Margaret and the Dragon, glows with the victory of this immortal passion. A fair, gentle maiden, alone, and unweaponed save with a palm-branch, is making the journey of life. In a narrow, rugged defile in the mountains she encounters the dragon. With cheeks unblanched, and firm step, she walks on buoyantly as if in a garden with the flowers and the butterflies. She is unconscious of the beast — and the beast is impotent to harm her. She treads upon the bat-like wings, the monster tears the earth with his claws in his rage and lashes the

mountains with his scaly tail till they shake—the maiden notices nothing of it all, not even that she has conquered. With purpose in her eye, and her face aglow with passion, she sees only the light playing on the distant mountain-tops.

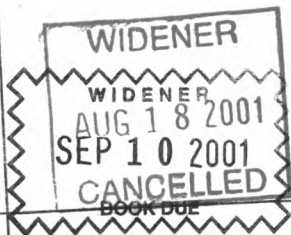
It is the Beautiful Soul made invincible and immortal by the vision of the Grail.



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